

文化單元 (一) Culture Notes

Kinship Titles



明文，你好。她們是……？



妳好。Gloria，她們是我的 cousin。這是我堂妹王明美，
這是我表妹張安安。



Huh?

都是 cousin ？ 表妹 (biǎomèi) ？ 堂妹 (tángmèi) ？

Why does Wang, Mingwen refer to Wang, Mingmei as his “堂妹 (tángmèi)” but Zhang, Anan as his “表妹 (biǎomèi)” even though they are both his cousins? In traditional society, everyone had large families with many relatives, and most of these large families lived together. There are very specific kinship titles for family members and relatives because people value relationships between people and respect seniority within the family. People outside of the family can distinguish the exact relationship between two people by their respective kinship titles. It is necessary for people to address their relatives by the correct titles.

The terms to address each relative of the extended family are all different. Beginning on the father's side: “爺爺 (yéye)” is paternal grandfather. “奶奶 (nǎinai)” is paternal grandmother. “伯伯 (bóbo)” is father's older brother. “叔叔 (shúshu)” is father's younger brother. “姑姑 (gūgu)” is father's sister. On the mother's side: “外公 (wàigōng)” is maternal grandfather. “外婆 (wàipó)” is maternal grandmother. “舅舅 (jiùjiu)” is mother's brother. “阿姨 (āyí)” is mother's sister.

The children of my “伯伯 (bóbo)” and “叔叔 (shúshu)” are my “堂 (táng) 兄弟姐妹”. The children of my “舅舅 (jiùjiu)” and “阿姨 (āyí)” are my “表 (biǎo) 兄弟姐妹”.



